the state. This time, such was the pull of communal sentiments that not only did Sharma defeat Akbar, but he did so by a margin of 40,000 votes. Similarly, in Saja, the BJP fielded Ishwar Sahu, the father of Bhuneshwar Sahu, who was killed in the April riots. Ishwar, with no political history, went on to defeat seven-term MLA and Congress veteran Ravindra Chaubey. "The Hindutva issue was playing as an undercurrent, which the Congress failed to identify," says Sudeep Shrivastava, a political analyst.

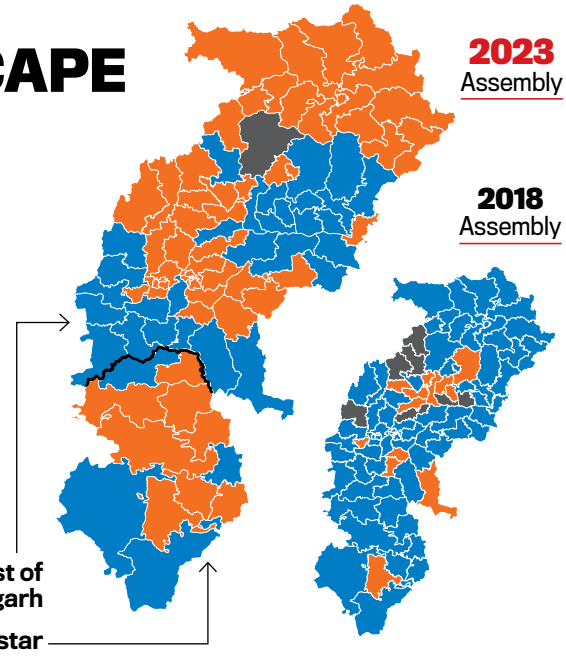
NAILING THE CONGRESS COFFIN

The BJP's high-intensity campaign did the rest, as a raft of senior national leaders hammered away at corruption allegations against the Baghel government. As many as 100 public shows were held in the state featuring Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Union home minister Amit Shah and various central BJP leaders and chief ministers. PM Modi was the face of the campaign and led six meetings, while Shah addressed nine. party president J.P. Nadda 10, Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath seven, and women and child development minister Smriti Irani another set of nine meetings. The Congress, on the other hand, had no such high-profile campaigners.

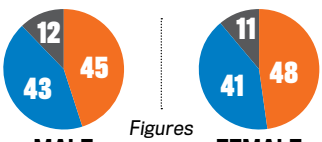
However, the turning point in the election came towards the end, when PM Modi gave in to the state unit's demand to announce a bonus on paddy procurement. Ahead of the 2018 polls, the Congress, too, had unveiled similar measures, in addition to farm loan waivers. Back then, the BJP had not allowed its state unit to announce either. In fact, from 2014 onwards, the Centre had disallowed procurement at a bonus. So, if a state procured food grains above MSP, it was left to its own devices to dispose of the grain in excess of its PDS requirement. The Congress in Chhattisgarh had been doing exactly that for the past five years, paying the bonus amount to farmers in three instalments through the year.

BATTLE LANDSCAPE

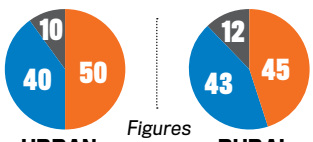
THE BJP SWEPT THE TRIBAL-DOMINATED NORTH AND SOUTH CHHATTISGARH, WINNING 14 AND EIGHT SEATS IN THE TWO REGIONS, RESPECTIVELY. IN TOTAL, THE PARTY WON 17 OF THE 29 ST-RESERVED SEATS IN THE STATE



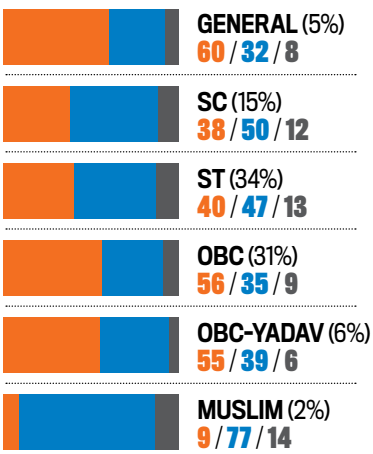
GENDER



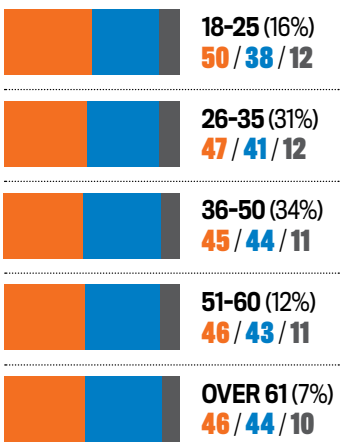
GEOGRAPHY



CASTE BREAK-UP



AGE GROUPS



Source: Axis My India and India Today bureau; Figures in percentage
Figures in () indicate share in total population

On November 3, just four days before the first phase of polling on November 7, the BJP revisited that decision and came out with its 'Modi ki Guarantee' manifesto, which promised Rs 3,100—paid in a single instalment—as paddy procurement price. Besides the farmers, Rs 10,000 a year was promised to the landless poor as well, there were cooking gas cylinders for Rs 500, and the Mahtari Vandan Scheme offered Rs 12,000 annually